

ESSENTIAL SKILL

Tools

The Right Tool Makes Resources Useful

Food, water, wood, shelter materials, and repair supplies are useful only when you can work with them. A few dependable hand tools can do an enormous amount when electricity, fuel, or outside help is unavailable.

KEEP SIMPLE TOOLS. KNOW HOW TO USE THEM.

START WITH HAND TOOLS

Choose tools that still work without the grid

No electricity required

No charged battery required

No fuel required

Repairable and maintainable

BEFORE EVERY USE

Inspect the tool, choose the right tool for the job, wear suitable protection, clear the work area, and stop if the task exceeds your skill.

BUILD BY FUNCTION

Basic emergency tool kit

CUTTING AND WOOD

Shape and prepare

- Hand saw
- Bow saw
- Axe
- Splitting maul
- Hatchet
- Utility knife

DIGGING AND MOVING

Lift and clear

- Shovel
- Spade
- Rake
- Pry bar
- Buckets

REPAIR

Adjust and restore

- Hammer
- Screwdrivers
- Pliers
- Adjustable wrench
- Socket or wrench set
- Pipe wrench
- Tape measure

FASTENING

Hold and cover

- Nails and screws
- Wire
- Rope and cord
- Duct tape
- Zip ties
- Tarps

Wood tools

If you depend on wood for heat or cooking, you need a way to cut, split, move, and keep it dry.

Bow saw + Axe + Splitting maul + Gloves

These four items can accomplish a great deal without fuel or electricity, but cutting and splitting require instruction, a clear work zone, secure footing, and eye protection.

INSPECT BEFORE THE EMERGENCY

Keep tools usable

Edges	Sharp, clean, and protected from damage.	Handles	Tight, dry, and free of cracks or splinters.
Metal	Free of serious rust, bends, or loose heads.	Moving parts	Clean, correctly adjusted, and lightly lubricated when appropriate.
Blades	Saw teeth straight and suitable for the material.	Supplies	Files, sharpening stones, spare blades, oil, and replacement handles available.

A dull or damaged cutting tool may require more force and can be harder to control. Learn the correct maintenance method for each tool.

SIMPLE ITEMS, MANY USES

Rope, tarps, and buckets

SECURE

Rope or cord

Tie down loads, hang tarps, organize equipment, and support temporary repairs. Never trust unknown cordage for climbing or life safety.

COVER

Tarps

Protect roof damage, firewood, equipment, windows, and temporary shelter from weather.

CARRY

Buckets

Move water, food, soil, ashes, cleaning water, and supplies. Label buckets by use.

PREVENT THE NEXT PROBLEM

Temporary repairs

A permanent repair may be impossible during an emergency. The immediate goal may be to stop water entry, cover a broken window, hold a door shut, slow a pipe leak, or protect supplies from rain.

Do not climb onto an unstable roof, enter a damaged structure, or improvise near live utilities. A repair is not worth another injury.

KNOW THE VALVE, NOT JUST THE WRENCH

Water and plumbing tools

☐ Adjustable wrench

☐ Pipe wrench

☐ Pliers

☐ Screwdrivers

☐ Plumbing tape

☐ Hose clamps

☐ Spare washers

☐ Buckets

Find the main water shutoff now

Tag it clearly, verify that it is operable without forcing it, keep the correct tool nearby, and show responsible household members where it is.

WATER AND ELECTRICITY ARE A DANGEROUS COMBINATION

Electrical safety

Locate and label the main electrical panel and important circuits before an emergency. Teach responsible household members the approved shutoff procedure for the building.

Do not touch exposed wiring, enter standing water near electrical equipment, or work on a live system. Repairs belong to a qualified electrician.

LEARN THE EXACT PROCEDURE FROM THE SUPPLIER

Gas and fuel shutoffs

Natural gas, propane, oil, and other fuel systems differ. Ask the supplier or a qualified professional which valve applies, which tool is required, and when it should be operated.

✗ Actually shut off gas merely to practice.

✗ Operate an unfamiliar valve by guessing.

✗ Turn gas service back on yourself after it has been shut off.

✗ Remain in a building if you smell gas or hear blowing or hissing.

If gas is suspected, avoid flames and electrical switches, get everyone out, and call the gas company or emergency services from a safe location.

MAKE TOOLS EASY TO FIND

Keep tools together

Create a clearly labeled emergency-tool area. Keep priority tools and utility shutoff tools accessible, not buried behind stored supplies. Use a return system if several people share them.

Emergency Tools

ONE KNOWN LOCATION, CLEARLY LABELED

SAFETY EQUIPMENT IS PART OF THE KIT

Protect the person using the tool

☐ Work gloves suited to the task

☐ Safety glasses

☐ Hearing protection when needed

☐ Task-appropriate respiratory protection

☐ Sturdy shoes or boots

☐ First-aid kit

☐ Headlamp or flashlight

☐ Clear, well-lit work area

Do not use a tool you do not understand

Chainsaws, axes, generators, power saws, ladders, and electrical equipment can create another emergency when used without training. Read the manual, learn from a competent person, and practice under normal conditions.

A tool you know how to use is worth more than ten tools you do not understand.

AVOID THESE

Common mistakes

✗ Depend entirely on power tools.

✗ Keep tools where nobody can find them.

✗ Use dull cutting tools or damaged handles.

✗ Use an axe or saw without a clear work zone.

✗ Work alone on a hazardous task when help is available.

✗ Use electrical tools around standing water.

✗ Attempt repairs beyond your knowledge or training.

✗ Forget protective equipment.

✗ Own critical tools you have never used.

TRY THIS NOW

Five-tool practice

Choose the five tools you expect to matter most, such as a hand saw, axe, hammer, adjustable wrench, and shovel.

1. Find each tool without searching.
2. Inspect its edge, handle, moving parts, and overall condition.
3. Identify its protective equipment and safe work zone.
4. Explain how it is maintained or sharpened.
5. Use it for one small, low-risk task under normal conditions.
6. Ask another person to locate it without your help.

For utility shutoffs, practice locating and explaining them without actually shutting off gas.

BEFORE AN EMERGENCY

Quick checklist

☐ I have basic hand tools and know where they are.

☐ Cutting tools are maintained and handles are secure.

☐ I have rope, tarps, buckets, and repair supplies.

☐ I know and have labeled the main water shutoff.

☐ I know where the electrical panel is.

☐ I obtained correct gas or fuel instructions from the supplier.

☐ Shutoff tools are accessible.

☐ I have gloves, eye protection, and sturdy footwear.

☐ I have practiced with the tools I expect to depend on.

REMEMBER

Natural resources become useful when you can work with them.

Simple hand tools do not need electricity.

**KEEP IT SIMPLE. KEEP IT SHARP. KNOW
HOW TO USE IT.**

Official guidance

Always follow manufacturer instructions, local utility directions, and task-specific training.

Ready.gov: Utility Safety Skills(<https://www.ready.gov/safety-skills>)

Ready.gov: Build an Emergency Kit(<https://www.ready.gov/kit>)

OSHA: Hand and Power Tools(<https://www.osha.gov/hand-power-tools>)
